

Effective instructions

Effective instructions make it easier for our child/ren to follow them successfully. We can then praise them and increase their self-esteem.

Expectations are made clear, reasonable, and understood.

Effective instructions are easily understood (not confusing).

Full attention – get close to them, hold their shoulder and get down on their level.

Freedom to make choices wherever possible increases their confidence.

Eye contact – if your child is comfortable with this it can ensure they are listening.

Clear and positive e.g. “Hold on tight” rather than “Don’t fall”

Tell them what you want them to do- rather than say “Don’t...”

It is better to keep things simple – what is most important?

Vague instructions do not help – be specific e.g. “Keep the paint on the paper”

Ensure they can realistically do what you are asking.

Impertative to use manners- be polite - say “Please” and “Thank you”

Not giving options – don’t say “Shall we...?” “Let’s...” “Why don’t we...”

Saying instructions in the order you want them done avoids confusion!

Time – children take longer to process – give them the 5-10 seconds they need!

Reasons – explain why you are asking them to do something.

Use words that they understand, show them/practice with them.

Compliment your child/ren - praise them for following your instructions.

Try not to give unnecessary instructions – we often give far too many!

Instructions can be given using visuals/lists to avoid “nagging.”

One instruction at a time – do not overwhelm them!

Notice – give warnings/reminders and tell them when you want it to be done by.

Statements such as “you always” or “you never” become self-fulfilling – avoid them!

First and then

First think of what you would like them to do

Instructions – make them simple and clear

Refusal can be met with first and then.

State the instruction again and offer them something they can do afterwards.

Take control by saying First ... and then...

Avoid shouting – be calm and respectful.

Not giving in – only use if you are prepared to stick to what you say.

Develop their ability to choose wisely. Praise them as soon as they do what you asked.

Trust is built when you praise them and follow with the “then.”

Hear what they say and calmly repeat the “First and then” statement if needed.

Ensure you do not give in to any whining/moaning/shouting etc.

Next, they learn to choose what happens to them by their own actions.



Rewording instructions

Think of some instructions you give to your child on a regular basis.

Are they necessary? Are they clear? Have you clearly shown them what you would like?

Reword some instructions you use now into positive, clear, respectful instructions.

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Think of times that you can use first and then to prevent you nagging and to encourage your child's co-operation.

Write down some examples of what you will say (Don't forget your praise afterwards).